

EU V: European Citizenship and Identity (AUW)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: McCormick, J. (2021), *Understanding the European Union: A Concise Introduction*, ch. "The EU and its Citizens," pp. 88–109 · Szczerbiak, A. & Taggart, P. (2024), "Euroscepticism and anti-establishment parties in Europe," *Journal of European Integration* 46(8), pp. 1171–1191.

Theme of the lecture. After four lectures on the EU's history and machinery, this one turns to its **people**: has decades of integration actually produced a **European identity** — and does it matter? The lecture runs a chain — **formal citizenship** → **identity** → **public attitudes** → **political consequences** — stressing that *one does not automatically lead to the next*. Along the way it tackles the democratic deficit, how citizens are represented, *why* individuals come to support or oppose the EU (four mechanisms), and the rise of **Euroscepticism** and the **politicization** of European integration.

★ **The heart of the lecture:** the EU's future "depends on the support of its citizens, not just its elites" — so citizen **attitudes** are now a real constraint on integration. But the links are loose: holding an **EU passport** (formal citizenship) does not make you **feel** European (identity), which does not determine whether you **support** the EU (attitudes), which in turn shapes what leaders can do (consequences). Europe has moved from a **permissive consensus** (leave it to the elites) to a **constraining dissensus** (a politically contested project).

Red thread: what kind of political community are EU citizens citizens of — and when do citizens' identities get *activated* to reshape integration?

Key concepts to apply: EU citizenship (rights + the Art. 20 "additional, not replacement" limit) · the democratic deficit · the knowledge deficit · federation vs confederation (the Moravcsik–Franklin debate) · indirect / direct / engagement channels of representation · second-order elections · identity as constructed, contested, changeable · nested / cross-cutting / marble-cake identities · civic vs exclusionary construction of Europe · the two-way identity ↔ integration relationship · permissive consensus → constraining dissensus · the four attitude mechanisms (utility · identity · cues · benchmarking) · hard vs soft Euroscepticism · Euroscepticism vs anti-establishment politics (Szczerbiak & Taggart's five clusters; the "fungible issue") · politicization of identities.

The core puzzle, and the citizenship → identity → attitudes → consequences chain

Core: you are a **national citizen** and a **European Union citizen** — but what does that actually mean, and does it tell us anything about whether you *feel* European or *support* the EU?

- **The puzzle:** the EU is **not a state**, so what kind of political community are EU citizens citizens of? EU citizenship exists **alongside** national citizenship and grants rights tied to membership of the Union.
- **The lecture's chain:** *formal citizenship* → *identity* → *public attitudes* → *political consequences*. **Main idea:** one layer does **not** automatically produce the next; there are multiple layers of interaction between

them.

- **Why this is political:** the future of integration "depends on the support of its citizens, not just its elites." **Public opinion actively constrains leaders** — so understanding citizen attitudes is essential to understanding the EU's future challenges.

Three theories, three ways of thinking about citizens

Core: the three integration theories from earlier lectures each frame the citizen differently — keep them as lenses throughout.

Lens	How it sees the citizen
Liberal intergovernmentalism	citizens → domestic preferences → national governments → interstate bargaining
Supranationalism / neofunctionalism	spillover: integration creates institutions, rules and actors that develop their own dynamics
Constructivism	identity, norms and socialization shape interests — and integration can reshape identities

What does EU citizenship actually give you? (more important, yet less than it seems)

Core: EU citizenship is a real bundle of rights, but by treaty it is an **add-on** to national citizenship, not a replacement — "both more important and yet less than it seems" (McCormick).

The rights it grants (deck):

- **Free movement and residence** across the Union.
- **Vote (and stand) in European Parliament elections.**
- **Vote in local/municipal elections where you reside** (but **not** national elections).
- **Consular protection** from any other member state when outside the EU and your own state has no representation.
- The right to **petition the EU institutions** (Parliament, the Ombudsman).

The limits:

- **Additional, not a replacement.** Maastricht created EU citizenship; the **Lisbon Treaty, Art. 20** states it "shall be additional to and not replace national citizenship." You remain a citizen of your **home state**.
- **Social and psychological barriers** to real free movement remain — language, customs, laws, road rules, banking, local products. "There is a limit to how much common EU laws will help" an Italian settling in Estonia.

Background: citizenship, and the "people's Europe"

- What normally distinguishes a citizen from a non-citizen (McCormick, via Joppke): the right to **vote and run for office**, jury service, eligibility for the **armed forces**, protection from forcible removal, consular protection abroad, right of **re-entry**, recognition by other states, and a **sense of belonging**. Many ordinary rights (equality before the law, property, free speech, minimum welfare) are enjoyed by **non-citizens too** — which is why EU citizenship is thinner than it sounds.
 - It took leaders **30+ years** to attend to how ordinary Europeans related to integration. The **Adonnino Committee** (1984–85) proposed the symbols of a "**people's Europe**": the burgundy **European passport** (from 1986), the **flag** (12 gold stars on blue, borrowed from the **Council of Europe, 1955** — the number is *not* the number of members), **Europe Day** (9 May, the Schuman Declaration anniversary), and the **anthem** (the "Ode to Joy," Beethoven's Ninth).
 - The **Single European Act** eased **free movement of people** (provided one had health insurance and enough income not to be a "burden"); a **1991 directive** introduced **mutual recognition of professional qualifications** (3+ years of training).
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★ The democratic deficit

Core: the democratic deficit is "the gap between the actions taken by the EU institutions and the ability of ordinary Europeans to **directly influence** those actions" (McCormick).

- **The deck's framing:** the **Commission (unelected)** proposes legislation and governs areas of **exclusive supranational competence**; treaty changes have often been negotiated **among elites**. *But* the EU also combines **direct and indirect** democratic channels — so the charge is contested.
- **Evidence critics cite (McCormick):** few of the EU15 held referendums on joining; **Maastricht and Lisbon** were negotiated largely behind closed doors; the Commission faces little direct accountability; **Council and COREPER** mostly meet **in secret**; the **EP cannot raise revenue or initiate laws**; citizens have **no say over Court appointments**; and formal citizen rights are modest.

The key move: it depends whether you treat the EU as a federation or a confederation

Core: McCormick's central argument — "*everything depends on how the EU is understood.*"

- As a **federation**, its democratic credentials would be **weak**.
- As a **confederation**, representation is *expected* to be **indirect** (national governments answer to voters and represent them in the EU's chambers) — so its procedures are "almost everything we could expect." The irony: to satisfy critics, the EU would have to **become the federation they oppose**.
- **The scholarly debate:** **Franklin (1996)** — the lack of accountability is a "**crisis of legitimacy**." **Moravcsik (2002)** — EU institutions are hemmed in by checks (narrow mandates, fiscal limits, super-majorities, separation of powers), so EU policy-making is "**clean, transparent, effective and politically responsive**."
- **Useful data point:** trust in the **EU has consistently outstripped trust in national governments**; and **2018 was the first year ever** that a majority of Europeans felt their **voice counts** in the EU.

The knowledge deficit

Core: a second, "more fundamentally troublesome" deficit — most Europeans simply **don't understand how the EU works**, which makes opinion unstable and leaves a gap "into which Eurosceptics have walked."

- **Stats:** in 2004, 55% thought the EU was created just after WWI and 50% did not know the EP was directly elected; by 2019, 70% knew the EP is elected, but 31% **had never heard of the Council of the EU**.
- **Consequence:** referendums are often decided on **other** grounds — the 2005 French vote ($\approx 75\%$ admitted knowing little about the treaty; many voted on Chirac) and **Brexit 2016** (false claims; votes driven by the government of the day, the economy and immigration).
- **Exam tip (deck):** distinguish "I/many people dislike a decision" from "the decision-making process is insufficiently democratic." Only the second is a genuine democratic-deficit claim.

How are EU citizens represented?

Core: three routes, running from arm's-length to hands-on.

Channel	How it works	Bodies / tools
Indirectly	through your national government	European Council · Council of the EU
Directly	through your elected EU representatives	European Parliament
Through engagement	participation and active citizenship	referendums · EU-level interest groups · the European Ombudsman · the <u>European Citizens' Initiative (ECI)</u>

- **European elections** (every 5 years since 1979, by **PR**) are the one directly democratic channel — but they are "**second-order**" elections (Reif & Schmitt 1980): fought on **national** issues, used to send messages to national governments, with **low turnout** (from 63% in 1979 down to $\sim 43\%$ in 2009/2014, recovering to $\sim 51\%$ in 2019).
- **Referendums** on EU questions have multiplied (**46 votes, 37 since 1992**; Ireland 8, Denmark 7). Two types: on **membership** and on **treaties**. Denmark was the **first to reject a treaty** (Maastricht, 1992, by 50.7%); France and the Netherlands **killed the Constitutional Treaty in 2005**. The **euro** was put to a vote only in **Denmark and Sweden** — **both said No** — so no euro government has dared ask.
- **Interest groups** (e.g. **BusinessEurope**, the **ETUC**) cluster in Brussels and **help offset the deficit** by giving citizens a channel that **bypasses national governments**.
- **European Ombudsman:** handles complaints of **maladministration** by EU bodies (except the Courts); the **Commission** draws most complaints.
- **European Citizens' Initiative (ECI):** a Lisbon innovation — **1 million citizens from at least 7 member states** can invite the Commission to propose legislation.

European identity: who are "we"?

Core: European identity is **not a fact to be measured** — it is a set of **contested ideas** about who "we" are, which values define Europe, who belongs, and where Europe ends.

- In **social constructivism**, identities are **constructed, contested and changeable** — not fixed or natural.

Multi-level identities: one identity does not replace another

Core: national and European identities **coexist**; there are three ideal-typical ways they fit together.

Type	Image	Meaning
Nested	Russian doll	smaller collective identities sit inside larger ones
Cross-cutting	overlapping circles	different identity markers overlap with no single hierarchy
Blended	marble cake	national and European identities interact and change one another

Civic vs exclusionary constructions of Europe

Core: "Europe" is something political actors **construct** — and they build it in opposite ways.

	Civic construction	Exclusionary construction
Basis	shared civic values	essentialist cultural markers
Content	freedom, democracy, equality, human rights, rule of law	Europe as a bounded cultural community
Stance	inclusive, values-based	threatened by migration, enlargement, outside influence
Example	the Lisbon Treaty preamble ("universal values... freedom, democracy, equality and the rule of law")	the Front National (2007) on Turkey ("an Asian country... does not have its place in Europe")

The two-way relationship: identity ↔ integration

Core: constructivism's key claim — causation runs **both ways**.

- **Identity shapes integration:** what actors consider **desirable or legitimate** depends on socially shared identities, values and norms.
- **Integration shapes identity:** membership, institutions, **socialization** and shared experiences change how actors understand themselves.

★ From permissive consensus to constraining dissensus

Core: the politics of integration has flipped — citizens used to be bystanders; now they are a brake.

	Permissive consensus	Constraining dissensus (Hooghe & Marks)
Citizens	"leave Europe to the elites"; largely accepted or ignored integration	Europe is politically contested
Effect on leaders	free hand	public opinion increasingly constrains what leaders can do

- The turning point was **Maastricht (1992)**: the **Danish No**, the UK's forced **ERM exit**, and the French "**petit oui**" put integration on the public radar and began to erode the permissive consensus (McCormick).

★ Why does one citizen support the EU and another oppose it? Four mechanisms

Core: attitudes toward the EU are driven by four overlapping logics — **utility, identity, cues, benchmarking**. Learn to apply all four to a single voter.

Mechanism	The question	Core logic
Utility	"What's in it for me?"	weigh costs vs benefits of membership
Identity	"Who are we?"	belonging, values, perceived cultural threat
Cues	"What do people I trust tell me?"	shortcuts from parties and media
Benchmarking	"Compared with what?"	judge the EU against an alternative

Utility — "what's in it for me?"

- Citizens weigh **benefits** (trade, mobility, investment) against **costs** (adjustment, regulation, redistribution, perceived loss of control).
- **Individual level:** the "**winners**" of integration (higher education, income, skills) are more supportive — the **elite-mass gap**.
- **National level:** citizens in countries that **benefit** (through trade or redistribution) are more supportive.

Identity — "who are we?"

- A strong attachment to the nation does not by itself imply opposition to the EU.

- But where national identity is **exclusive** (hostile to other cultures), Europe is easily framed as a **threat to "us"** → more likely to oppose the EU.

Cues — "what do trusted actors tell me?"

- Most citizens **do not follow EU politics closely** (information asymmetry), so **parties and media provide shortcuts**. Voters of **pro-EU parties** are more likely to be pro-EU — the cues matter even when the issue is not intrinsically important to the voter.

Benchmarking — "compared with what?"

- **Democratic benchmark**: citizens in **high-quality national democracies** may be less supportive of the EU.
- **Contrast / scapegoat**: citizens **dissatisfied with their national government** may become **more** supportive, seeing the EU as an alternative.
- **Economic benchmark**: citizens in **less affluent** states judge the EU on **economic** performance; those in **more affluent** states judge it on **political/democratic** criteria.
- **Worked case (deck)**: a young Danish voter *benefits economically* from EU mobility and thinks Denmark would struggle outside (**utility → support**), *but* identifies strongly as Danish (**identity → oppose**) and follows a Eurosceptic party (**cues → oppose**) — the mechanisms pull in **different directions**.

Euroscepticism: opposition to what?

Core: Euroscepticism is **not monolithic** — it runs from wanting reform to wanting out. Taggart & Szczerbiak's classic split:

	Hard Euroscepticism	Soft Euroscepticism
Object	opposition to EU integration in principle	opposition to the current direction / pace / extent
Endpoint	can mean leaving — opposition to membership itself	membership still accepted in principle
Framing	system opposition	policy opposition

- McCormick: the term was coined in **mid-1980s Britain**; arguments vary by issue, time and country and are often "**less about hostility to integration than about immigration**." Eurosceptic parties made large gains in the **2019 EP elections**. Yet the **Spring 2019 Eurobarometer** found **59%** of Europeans wanted **more** decisions taken at EU level (only 32% opposed).

★ Is Euroscepticism the same as anti-establishment politics? (Szczzerbiak & Taggart 2024)

Core: No — there is no *necessary* link. Classifying 77 parties in 30 countries (expert-informed, 2018–19), the authors find Euroscepticism is a "fungible issue" that domestic politics frames differently; anti-establishment must be treated as a party feature in its own right.

- Anti-establishment ≠ anti-system ≠ populism. Anti-system (Sartori) rejects democracy itself; anti-establishment accepts the system but attacks the **entrenched elite**. It varies on two dimensions: **scope** (political / economic / cultural; left or right) and **action** (revolutionary → reformist → merely disruptive).
- The five clusters:

Cluster	Relationship	Examples
1. Anti-establishment, NOT Eurosceptic	see the EU as part of the solution to bad national elites; mostly CEE ("return to Europe")	En Marche (FR) · Save Romania Union
2. Eurosceptic, NOT anti-establishment	object to the EU project , not "the elite"; often governing parties	UK Conservative Party
3. Strong association (largest)	domestic + EU elites seen as entwined — possible " EU-isation "	National Rally · AfD · Five Star · The League · Fidesz · Syriza · Swiss People's Party
4. Both, but little interaction	the two run on separate tracks ; mostly CEE	Law and Justice (PL) · Austrian Freedom Party · Vox
5. Anti-establishment, Euroscepticism not salient	the EU is a " <u>touchstone of dissent</u> " (Taggart 1998) — a " box to be ticked ," not the appeal	Sweden Democrats · Sinn Féin · Podemos

- **Central thesis:** "Euroscepticism is a very fungible issue, and the structures of **domestic politics** play a crucial role in framing the national reception of European integration."
- **Take-home exercise (deck):** for the **Danish People's Party**, **Fidesz**, **Five Star**, **En Marche** / **Renaissance**, ask what each really opposes — EU integration? a specific policy? EU institutions/elites? **domestic** elites? national identity/cultural change? (often several at once).

★ Politicization: crises activate identities

Core: a crisis does **not** automatically lower EU support. **Politicization** is the process by which **political elites** (parties, movements) **activate/mobilize identities**, which then feed back into political processes. It turns on three questions: **solidarity** (who should help whom?), **responsibility** (who should fix it?), and **borders & belonging** (who belongs, and who decides?).

	Eurozone crisis	Schengen / migration crisis
Type	economic	cultural and political
Driving question	<i>how much solidarity?</i>	<i>who belongs in Europe?</i>
Focus	disputes over responsibility and financial support	borders and belonging
Outcome	Europeans largely favoured European solutions ; limited "us vs them" framing	Open Europe vs "Fortress Europe"; stronger mobilization of national identity

★ Synthesis — citizens shape integration, integration reshapes politics

Core: the chain runs **both ways**, and **identity is the hinge**.

- **Citizens can shape integration:** domestic preferences, political constraints, electoral incentives and pressure on national governments (the **LI** lens).
- **Integration can reshape politics:** new institutions, rights, **socialization** and new political conflicts (the **supranationalism** lens).
- **Identity links the two:** identities shape interests, while political processes reshape identities (the **constructivism** lens). This is why the opening chain — *formal citizenship* → *identity* → *attitudes* → *consequences* — never runs in only one direction.

Cases & examples

- **The young Danish voter** — the four mechanisms (utility/identity/cues/benchmarking) pull in different directions (deck).
- **French 2005 referendum** — rejected the Constitutional Treaty; ~75% admitted knowing little, many voted on Chirac (knowledge deficit).
- **Brexit 2016** — the first whole country to vote to leave; driven by views of the government, the economy and immigration more than the EU itself.
- **Greenland (1982)** — the first territory to leave the Community.
- **The symbols of a "people's Europe"** — passport, flag (12 stars), Europe Day, "Ode to Joy" (Adonnino).
- **Lisbon preamble vs Front National (2007) on Turkey** — civic vs exclusionary constructions of Europe.
- **Eurozone vs Schengen crises** — solidarity framing vs borders-and-belonging framing.
- **Party cases (Szczerbiak & Taggart)** — En Marche (anti-establishment, pro-EU); UK Conservatives (Eurosceptic, not anti-establishment); Five Star / National Rally / Fidesz (both, entwined).

Key terms

Term	Meaning
EU citizenship	Rights tied to Union membership, additional to (not replacing) national citizenship (Lisbon Art. 20)
Democratic deficit	Gap between EU actions and citizens' ability to directly influence them
Knowledge deficit	Most citizens don't understand how the EU works, making opinion unstable
Federation vs confederation	The yardstick for judging the deficit (Moravcsik: as a confederation, the EU is responsive enough)
Second-order elections	EP elections fought on national issues, low turnout (Reif & Schmitt)
European Citizens' Initiative	1 million citizens from 7+ states can invite a Commission proposal
Constructed / contested / changeable	How constructivism treats identity
Nested / cross-cutting / blended	The three ideal types of multi-level identity
Civic vs exclusionary Europe	Values-based vs culturally-bounded constructions of "Europe"
Permissive consensus	Citizens leave integration to elites
Constraining dissensus	Public opinion now limits what leaders can do (Hooghe & Marks)
Utility / Identity / Cues / Benchmarking	The four mechanisms behind EU support or opposition
Hard / Soft Euroscepticism	Opposition in principle (→ exit) vs opposition to the current direction
Anti-establishment	Opposition to an entrenched elite; varies by scope and action ; ≠ anti-system, ≠ populism
Touchstone of dissent	The EU as a marker of a party's oppositional identity , not its appeal (Taggart)
Fungible issue	Euroscepticism as malleable, framed differently across domestic contexts
Politicization	Elites activating identities around solidarity, responsibility, borders & belonging

Exam pointers

- **Run the chain** *formal citizenship* → *identity* → *attitudes* → *consequences*, and stress that **each link is loose** (an EU passport does not make you feel or vote European).
- **Apply the four mechanisms** (utility · identity · cues · benchmarking) to a concrete voter and show them **pulling in different directions** (the Danish-voter case).
- **Democratic deficit**: give **one argument for and one against**, hinging on **federation vs confederation** (Franklin vs Moravcsik); and distinguish "I dislike a decision" from "the process is undemocratic."

- **Hard vs soft Euroscepticism** with examples, and the key twist: **Euroscepticism** $\neq$ anti-establishment — cite Szczerbiak & Taggart's **five clusters** and the "**fungible issue**" thesis.
- **Civic vs exclusionary identity** (Lisbon preamble vs Front National) and the **three multi-level** types.
- **Politicization**: contrast the **eurozone** (solidarity) and **Schengen** (borders & belonging) crises, and note a crisis does **not** automatically cut EU support.
- Keep the **three lenses** (LI • supranationalism • constructivism) ready to read citizens, identity and attitudes.

★ Fun facts & memorable details (EU V: Citizenship & Identity)

Sticky bits from the citizenship-and-identity lecture.

- **The flag's 12 stars mean nothing numerical.** The ring of **12 gold stars** was adopted from the **Council of Europe (1955)**; it stands for completeness/unity, **not** the number of member states (a common exam trap).
 - **Greenland left in 1982.** Its ~53,000 voters made it the **first territory to leave** the Community — decades before Brexit made Britain the first whole country.
 - **"It is far to Oslo, but further to Brussels."** A 1972 Norwegian slogan capturing how EU opposition can be an extension of opposition to one's own capital elite.
 - **The euro has never won a referendum.** It was put to a public vote only in **Denmark and Sweden** — **both said No** — so none of the 19 euro governments dared ask their citizens.
 - **2018 was a first.** For the first time ever, a **majority** of Europeans said their **voice counts** in the EU — and trust in the EU has long run **higher** than trust in national governments.
 - **In 2004, 55% thought the EU was founded just after WWI.** A vivid illustration of the knowledge deficit — and why Eurosceptics found an open goal.
 - **"Quintessentially anti-establishment."** Szczerbiak & Taggart's label for Italy's **Five Star Movement**; France's National Rally coined **"TUMPS"** for the mainstream parties it accused of colluding with Brussels, and **La France Insoumise** called for a **"Sixth Republic"** to sweep away an establishment "fused with the EU elite."
 - **Ireland has voted on Europe eight times.** A constitutional duty to hold treaty referendums gives a country of ~4 million the power to stall treaties for the whole EU (as with Nice and Lisbon).
-